

DIGITAL CAMERAS

Digital Cameras have helped the layman take up photography; they've made the learning curve a lot less steep. Their price and availability have made them very popular, and it's only getting better. Decent entry-level cameras can be had for as little Rs 7,000 to 8,000.

The dropping prices of memory cards has also helped.

Most of the technology has stayed more or less the same as compared to the previous generation; features like larger number of focus points in a scene and image stabilisation have become standard.

"Ultrazoom" or "pseudo-SLR" cameras refer to those that resembled D-SLRs in shape while being much smaller and cheaper. The zoom levels and the megapixel ratings have been the most prominent changes here. A few models launched by a few brands (Sony and Canon, for example) now fill the gap between point-and-shoot and Ultrazoom models.

POINT-AND-SHOOT CAMERAS

The Reigning Champion Canon PowerShot A570 IS

The winner from our last digital camera test—back in October 2007—was the Canon PowerShot A570 IS—a brilliant camera with a whole load of features and a highly competitive MRP of Rs 17,500. The market price now is much lower, and the camera seems to be available in the grey market at the Rs 9,000 to 10,000 mark. It has a 7.1 MP sensor with 4x optical zoom. One highlight was lovely, natural colours, not unlike most of the Canons in the category.

The Contender Canon PowerShot A650 IS

Canon has kept updating their cameras; the result of this is the A650 IS—an updated A640—which lacked image stabilisation. The A650 IS is a 12.1 megapixel camera (really a lot!) and gets into D-SLR territory in terms of resolution. In addition, the A710 IS has been replaced by the new A720 IS. The upgrades here aren't as substantial as with the A650 IS.

The Award Canon PowerShot A650 IS

The 12.1MP sensor apart, the optical zoom has been bumped all the way up to 6X from 4X—yet another great upgrade. This one as good as the A720 and the A710 in terms of zoom, but has a considerably higher megapixel rating. The \$400 price means around Rs 16,000. The market price will be lower than that, and the grey market price even lower. If



you're able to get the A650 IS for under Rs 12,000, it's a must-buy!

ULTRAZOOM CAMERAS

The Reigning Champion Sony Cyber-shot DSC-H7

We tested the Canon S3 IS in 2006, and we got to try the Sony DSC-H7 in our most recent comparison test. The latter is the Reigning Champion.

The Contenders Canon PowerShot S5 IS; Sony DSC-H9; Olympus SP-550UZ

The Canon S5 IS is known for its realistic colours and overall good quality. The Olympus SP-550UZ has the largest optical zoom of the lot—18x—but is a 7MP camera as compared to the rest, which are at around 8MP. The Sony DSC-H9 is very similar to the DSC-H7, with the exact same megapixel rating and optical zoom, but it has a larger, 3-inch screen.

The sensor and the image resolution you get are very similar to those of point-and-shoot cameras. Until last year, 12x of optical zoom was the norm for all manufacturers in this range. This year, however, Sony upped it a notch to 15x with the DSC-H7 and H9.

The Award Canon PowerShot S5 IS



The Zero1 in this category goes to the Canon PowerShot S5 IS, a brilliant camera for its price—in the grey market, it's around Rs 15,000. It's indeed a bit costlier than a typical point-and-shoot, but you get something like a point-and-shoot with features you'd find on D-SLRs. It's a great first-step camera for anyone who would like to start using a D-SLR but needs something affordable to train with.

GRAPHICS CARDS

This was clearly the year of the graphics card. 2007 saw the penetration of DX10 graphics cards into just about every segment, and the partial phasing out of DX9 cards. Though DX10 games are lagging behind the hardware, with poor optimisation and such, the desire to be future-proof is the driving force behind what's happening. We also saw the increased importance of HTPCs and gaming PCs last year; such PCs depend heavily on the graphics card, and this is another reason to have seen a large crop of DX10 cards coming into the market.

HIGH-END GRAPHICS CARDS

The Reigning Champion Galaxy 8800 Ultra

The Galaxy 8800 Ultra, based on the NVIDIA GeForce 8800 Ultra—currently the fastest GPU in the world—was easily the fastest-performing graphics card in our tests. With 768 MB of GDDR3 memory, this card just chomps up any game! Even at 8x Antialiasing and Anisotropic Filtering, the Galaxy didn't break the proverbial sweat. It comes with a stock NVIDIA heatsink that appears to do the job well. It makes for an ideal companion for a powerful gaming rig. And it goes without saying that this card will easily power any HTPC (an overkill if there ever was one!), although its audience is the hardcore gamer who will spend the Rs 30,000 it commands.

The Contender XFX 8800GTS Alpha Dog Edition

Another brute of a card, the new 65nm process enables NVIDIA to bump up clock speeds on the same formidable 128 shader units, so much so that the 8800GTS comes close to the 8800GTX, its elder brother.

The Award Galaxy 8800 Ultra

The Galaxy 8800 Ultra is the biggest, the fastest, and the costliest card out there. If you



have the dough (Rs 60,000 odd) then SLI two of these... and tell us how *Crysis* looks!

MID-RANGE GRAPHICS CARDS

The Reigning Champion ASUS EN8600GT

The mid-range category is the bread and butter for vendors, characterised by high sales and good profit margins. This is also where the most buying happens. The ASUS EN8600GT outperformed all the other 8600GT cards in our tests, and even demolished the 8600GTS cards. This overclocked marvel (540 stock vs. 625 EN8600GT) stayed cool throughout the tests. It is a good buy for the mid-range segment for a decent gaming machine, and a superb powerhouse for any HTPC, or someone who wants a combination of both.

The Contenders ATI Radeon HD3850

ATI's RV670, better known as the Radeon HD3850, enters the fray: a severely cut-down (as far as memory bandwidth goes) version of the older and much hotter HD2900 pro. Built around a new 55nm process, the HD3850 still features the 320 shader units and even more processing power due to higher clocks. The best part is that at Rs 12,000 or thereabouts, the HD3850 makes one fantastic option for a decent mid-range card.

The Award ASUS EN8600GT

While we're yet to see the new mid-range series from NVIDIA and ATI, the whole point



of a mid-range buy is the price point of Rs 8,000, beyond which we don't see anyone other than the discerning gamer spending. For its mix of price, performance, and low power consumption, the ASUS EN8600GT still hasn't got a worthy competitor to displace it of its lofty perch as our Zero1 award winner.